



EAT *and be*

You can't
catch me...



Every organism needs food to keep it going. Food provides energy that keeps cells working. Without energy, living things would not be able to move or breathe or grow.

PRODUCERS AND CONSUMERS

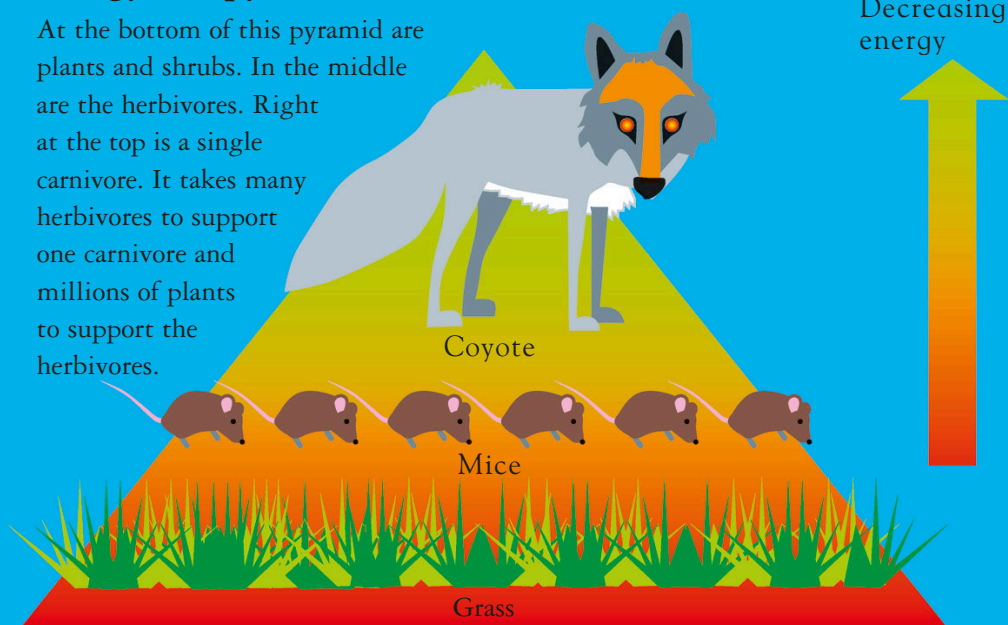
Organisms that make their own food are called **producers**. Plants are producers because they use the Sun's energy to make sugar. They do this by using what's around them—carbon dioxide, water, and sunlight. Animals cannot make their own food so they get energy from eating plants and other animals. They are **consumers**.

DECREASING ENERGY

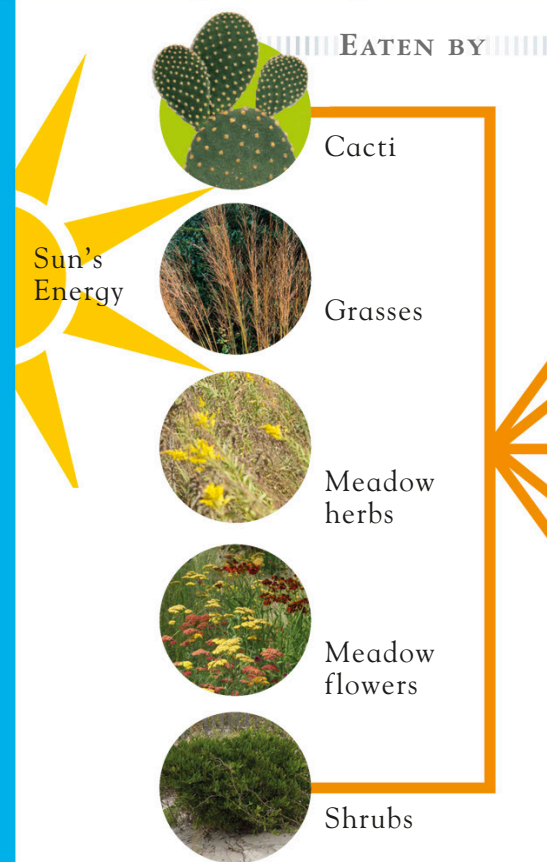
In a food chain, energy is passed from one link to the next, although some energy is lost with every link. When an herbivore eats a plant, some of the plant energy goes into the animal's muscles and organs and the rest is used to keep its body working. When a carnivore eats the herbivore, only the small amount of energy in the herbivore's muscles and organs is passed to the carnivore.

Energy-loss pyramid

At the bottom of this pyramid are plants and shrubs. In the middle are the herbivores. Right at the top is a single carnivore. It takes many herbivores to support one carnivore and millions of plants to support the herbivores.



FOOD WEBS



Producers found on a prairie include grasses, meadow flowers, small shrubs, and cacti. They all make their own food.